I Was Born in Chains (You Were Born to Free Me)

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Oracle Adora, Rogue Catra, Thief Catra, Slow Burn, Mutual Pining, Love Confessions, Falling In Love, Seeing the future, Alternate Universe - Historical, Historical-Ish I Think, Fluff, Love, Kidnapping, Rescue, Friends to Lovers, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Human Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), mutual love, Razz is Razzing, Bow is an Archer, plottwist, Disappeared Princess Glimmer

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by ResFlower

Summary

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"You're just going to leave me here?"She can't help but ask, mildly panicked. Since she was first outed as an oracle she's never been in the real world.

"Yes? I rescued you out of a moment of kindness, not for you to hang about."They reach up and pull back their hood.

Adora breathes sharply through her nose at the flash of recognition that hits her gut. It's the woman with the split eyes, handsome as ever, with unruly curls and a distrusting turn to her pink lips. The woman Adora longed to rescue her when she was a teen and then grew to fear ever meeting.

She outright glares at Adora, clearly peeved at having her plans disrupted. "My name is Catra. If I'm taking you any further than the next~~x~~town over , you will be paying me."

OR

Oracle Adora is rescued by a handsome thief that she's had visions of her whole life. Could there be more to it than that? Oracle AU.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

A new captor. Adora sighs ruefully as she takes in the army that has sieged war to attain her. The person who is clearly in charge~~s~~he knows her to be Sir Huntara from her visions~~b~~ows to her . "Oracle Adora. It is an honor to meet you."

"Sir Huntara." She acknowledges. There are gasps around the room ~~lik~~ely soldiers that believe her sight to be trickery .

"I have come to free you from King Peekablue's tyranny ." She puf fs up her chest as if this isn't what the King said when she was last captured. "And because I am not the Q~~u~~een of the Crimson W aste, you will no longer be passed hand in hand to unworthy kingdoms," Huntara says with a cocky smirk.

Adora fights the urge to roll her eyes. If it were that easy to be free of her prophecy, she would have remained with the Prince of the Northern Reach. She can't blame this knight, really . The prophecy isn't too clear~~s~~he was purposefully vague because she knew the conseq~~u~~ences of that prophecy .

Huntara carries on. "The prophecy says that the oracle will stop switching hands when one not of royal blood frees her of her trappings, of the servitude she faces for her gifts. I am a hardworking woman, who fought for my place in the Waste and started from nothing~~a~~nd since I am freeing the Oracle she belongs to the Waste!" The soldiers around her woop, raising their arms in victory .

Adora sighs, tired of the theatrics. She's no freer than she was this morning, tending to King Peekablue's every insecurity . She damn well knows the woman who is meant to save her~~it's~~ the woman of Adora's very first vision when she was fifteen years old. People gifted with the sight are given many visions throughout their lifetimes, but their first vision is always personal~~s~~ome are unlucky and see their own death, others a happy moment in time.

For Adora, it was the woman of split eyes, one almost golden and the other blue as the sky. The stranger was so beautiful she could

leave anyone breathless, Adora thought. She's had other blurry visions of her over time—she knows in some futures they are meant to be in love. But in all of them, this woman is the one who breaks Adora free, the one who fulfills the prophecy and makes it so that Adora never has to serve another king again.

Adora is snapped out of her reverie when she feels the chain come around her wrists. She sighs, not sure how the irony is lost on these soldiers. It's the paradox of the prophecy. Anyone willing to go to war for an Oracle will surely fail at giving her freedom.

She's stuffed into a carriage with Sir Huntara herself, which she supposes isn't uncommon. Most reactions veer in two opposite directions—people who think she's a witch and want nothing to do with her, or people who want to use her for their own machinations.

Huntara kicks up her feet, taking up half of the seat Adora is using. She makes herself smaller, although she eyes the muddy boots distastefully.

"So," Huntara says as she grins. "You knew my name. See anything else about me in your little visions?"

Adora holds a tight smile. "Nothing of note." It's not a lie really. She'd seen this very moment and a few others—Huntara is set to be demoted in a year, it will leave her angry and bitter. Adora doesn't much care for Huntara's job.

"Come on. Has to be *something*. Why don't you see something for me right now?" Huntara suggests eagerly.

"I'd really rather not." She says flatly.

"Why not? You can do it all the time can't you?" The knight demands.

She sighs. "I can, but reaching into the void for visions that are not meant to be is quite painful. And inadvisable. You might find things

you aren't prepared to know."Adora warns, just like she warns everyone else.

"I don't care if it hurts you, blondie."Huntara leans forward now, smile gone. "I'm probably not getting within ten feet of you after you're locked up tight wherever the queen wants you and I'm not losing my opportunity. So you better"—

Adora gasps when someone comes flying through a window and kicks Huntara straight in the face. Huntara looks dazed, scrunching onto one side of the carriage and then her face goes slack.

"That'll be nasty when she wakes."The person who swung into the carriage observed, their face concealed by a hood. The hooded figure turns to look at Adora and then freezes. "Fuck. They usually keep jewels in here."The person mutters in a low voice.

The figure eyes her for another moment, head dropping to look at her chained hands, then sighs. "Anyone on Huntara's bad side is probably alright. Come on."They urge. A gloved hand nimbly removes the chains and then the palm is outstretched to Adora.

She takes it without hesitation. There's never been a better chance of escape than this one and she'll be damned if she lets it slip. The hooded figure opens the carriage door and somehow, it's still moving, none of the Crimson Waste soldiers alerted of the figure's misdeeds. The figure pulls Adora over their shoulder with a soft grunt then jumps. It takes everything in her to stay silent and a doubt creeps in—maybe this is another long play from another faction to detain her. Before she can think too much, she's back on the ground in the forest that lines the main road on both sides.

"The Waste is full of idiot strategists. Know how to load a carriage with brawn but no smarts."The hooded person spits out distastefully. "What did you do to deserve their ire? I haven't seen them guard anything but valuables like this."They ask curiously.

Adora bites her lip. "I don't pretend to know why they did what they did when loading the carriage." It's not an outright lie and that's what matters.

Adora is surprised to discover the hooded person is shorter than she is. Whoever it is lifted her with such ease, she thought they'd be taller. She can't see their face at all~~the~~ hood must be weighed down or something, it hasn't moved~~but~~ the way their body freezes feels like they are evaluating Adora's credibility.

"Well, then we will call it a circumstance of good luck." They said. The voice is raspy and low, but it sounds womanly if Adora had to guess. The figure then turns and walks into the forest.

"You're just going to leave me here?" She can't help but ask, mildly panicked. Since she was first outed as an oracle she's never been in the real world. She couldn't begin to guess what she'd need to survive outside of the prisons she hates.

"Yes? I rescued you out of a moment of kindness, not for you to hang about." They complain. The person must see something on Adora's face because they sigh. They reach up and pull back their hood.

Adora breathes sharply through her nose at the flash of recognition that hits her gut. It's the woman with the split eyes, handsome as ever, with unruly curls and a distrusting turn to her pink lips. The woman Adora longed to rescue her when she was a teen and then grew to fear ever meeting.

She outright glares at Adora, clearly peeved at having her plans disrupted. "My name is Catra. If I'm taking you any further than the nex~~t~~town over, you *will* be paying me."

Catra sighs as she looks at the mystery woman who she's somehow been saddled with. The blonde is weird. There's no other word for it ~~wh~~en she's quiet, she looks like she's staring into another

dimension and when she talks, it's like she's afraid of Catra. Which is bullshit, because Catra rescued her and is now helping her get to... well, she's not sure if they've decided that.

She hasn't said her name, where she's from, or anything about herself~~if~~ Catra knew better she should drop her on her ass in the middle of the night. If it hadn't been for that terrified look on the woman's face at the prospect of being alone, Catra damn well would have.

Catra knows what it's like to find the task of surviving daunting—she's known it all too well since she was a child. It tugs at whatever softness is left inside of her. It's the reason she gives bread to the street kids and apparently, also why drags strange beautiful blonde women across two kingdoms.

They're around a fire Catra has built and the blonde seems immersed in the flames~~.~~ she hasn't blinked in minutes. Carefully , Catra puts a hand on her shoulder. "Are you okay?" She asks.

She doesn't get a response. Catra shakes her shoulder gently , then the blonde cries out as if she's been stabbed by a hot poker .

"Ugh. That never feels better ." She mutters under her breath before meeting Catra's eyes. "Catra." She says her name nearly constantly . It reminds Catra that she doesn't know hers.

Still, Catra furrows her brow, noting the etchings of pain in her eyes. "Are you okay? Did I do that?" She'd barely touched the blonde/

She winces, still holding her side. "It couldn't be helped." Is what she says.

"What do you mean?" It feels like she only has endless questions and the blonde refuses to answer any of them.

She sighs and looks up at Catra. "I~~m~~y name is Adora." She says warily, her voice tired as can be.

Catra's mouth gapes and she closes it again when she realizes. Of course, the blonde was guarded like a precious jewel—she damn well is one. The last Eternian oracle.

"Why would you ever tell me that." Catra can't wrap her head around how stupid Adora is being. She might as well tattoo the word loot on her forehead if she'll be giving out her name like that. "I could sell you to the highest bidder the moment we pass by a town big enough to have a courier."

"You won't." The way the blonde says it, so certain, makes Catra's skin crawl. "And even if you wanted to, I'd have to tell you eventually. My sight isn't an easy thing to hide."

"So what, you just trust me?" She says disbelievingly. If Catra were so trusting, she would have earned a knife in her back long ago.

Adora looks up at her with a surprisingly tender face. "I do trust you." She says softly as she swings her hair over her shoulder. "You pulled me out of a vision. It's almost more painful to leave a vision before the void wants me to go than it is to force one to happen." Her lips twist into a grimace. "I have more experience with the latter."

Catra furrows her brow and sits next to the blonde. "The visions hurt you?"

Adora shakes her head. "Not always. When a vision is natural, *meant to be*, it's easy. Effortless as breathing. I had two before you pulled me out of the last one." She informs Catra of this as if discussing the weather.

She can't help the curiosity that tingles at her spine. "What were they?"

She shrugs. "Nothing consequential. Do you remember that boy that was walking on the road while we were still on the edge of the forest?"

"Yeah." Catra damn near had a heart attack thinking it was Huntara's people. They manged to avoid him without being discovered, but it was a close thing.

"He doesn't know yet, but he will grow to be a blacksmith." She smiles as if happy for the boy. "I don't know what his family has now, but I sense it's a lot less than what he will have. He'll be satisfied." She lets out a wistful sigh.

"And the other one?" Her eyes snap to Catra's and a blush of all things forms on her cheeks.

"I'd rather not say." She mumbles, covering one cheek with her hand.

Catra eyes the blonde for a moment and decides to drop it. "I thought you'd be older." She states plainly. Everyone on Etheria knew of Oracle Adora, but few had ever seen her. Sometimes a kingdom would boast about having her but even that was sometimes built on lies.

Adora rolls her eyes. "People always think I'll look like some old witch, hobbled over and weak."

Catra laughs the blonde before her couldn't be further from that conjured image if she tried. "Well yeah! I've been hearing about the oracle for what feels like forever."

She nods sagely. "Well, there used to be more of us with the gift of sight. Some think the gods are angry and refuse to create more oracles. I think if the gods did give me this gift they have the good sense to know it brings nothing but madness." Her words turn strangled and bitter as she glares at the fire, not the peaceful stare of earlier but a violent thing.

"I'm sorry." She says softly. Catra has never thought much about the oracles. They were no concern to her. But being in the company of Adora makes it plain that she must be accustomed to a deeply lonely life.

Adora waves her hand. "No need. Ready to turn me in to the authorities?" She teases with a glint in her eye.

Much to her chagrin, Catra hasn't seriously considered it once in this entire conversation. Which makes no sense, turning in Adora would have her set for life. "For all you know, I could." She huffs to cover her embarrassment.

"You won't, and I'd stake my life on it. Clearly." She grins like she isn't leaving her life in Catra's hands.

"You don't know me." She protests. "This is a terrible decision." Catra can't help but warn. She wouldn't call herself disloyal by any means, but her loyalties are hard-won, and usually her own. This girl might be all-seeing, but she's soft. Fragile. Catra could crush her.

"It's mine to make." Adora points out. "Besides, you rescued me. Some would call that the behavior of one that's pure of heart."

She stares at the blonde, trying to figure out if she's serious. "I was robbing a carriage, Adora." She says slowly.

The oracle's eyes glaze over for a moment but she snaps out of it. "Huntara looked the type to deserve it." She finally settles on.

"Well, you aren't wrong about that." Catra concedes. She typically takes pleasure in stealing from those who have too much but she relishes in taking from the goons of the Crimson Waste.

Adora crosses her legs, resting her hands atop her lap. She looks more relaxed than Catra remembers seeing her. It suits the blonde. "So what do you do? When you aren't robbing carriages that is?" There's real interest in her gaze as she waits for an answer.

Catra sighs. "Trade, steal, survive." She shrugs. "Rinse and repeat." It isn't luxurious by any means. Sometimes she's romanced woman with the appearance of adventure and danger. She gets the feeling Adora would see right through that.

"Do you mostly stay in the forest? Do you have a family?" She fires off quickly . The questions seem to make her nervous.

Catra laughs. "I do stay in the forest a lot of the time but I also like to go into town. Ive never had a family to speak of." She eyes the blonde curiously. "What about you? Do oracles come with families?" She tries to keep the question light but Adora winces.

"I did have a family . Theyre gone now ." The statements feel loaded.

Still, Catra doesnt shy away from it. "So, two orphans then." Catra eyes her. "Im not sure that we are so dif ferent, you and I." Its an inkling she feels from more than the fact that they both dont belong to a family. Its more than that. They dont belong anywhere in this society, for very different reasons. Two sides of the same coin. Catra shakes her head, willing the thoughts to leave her. Theres no reason to waxpoetic about the oracle.

Adora holds her stare, something unfathomable hiding there. "Id wager youre right."

Catra ignores the chill down her spine that those blue eyes provoke, making her excuses to tend to the campfire.

Its unfair , how easy it is to care about Catra. It doesnt help that the universe seems hellbent on giving her visions of them together. Adora typically has visions once a day~~-less~~ so if shes forcing herself to look into the void for answers. Here with Catra however, shes having multiple visions a day~~-m~~any of them together and in love in some shapeless future that they share. Not only are the flashes of the future intoxicating, Catras present self is somehow even more charming than the visions.

Shes so *funny* even with her gruff exterior . Catra is guarded but the moment she lets Adora in, its clear that shes kind and loyal. Even without her visions, she thinks she would be completely taken with the thief.

She doesn't know what Catra thinks of her, though. She knows many people have their own ideas of what the oracle is supposed to be like. Adora typically falls short. There's an age-old sadness that creeps on her—the sadness of someone who is seen only for what she has to offer and not much else.

"What has you so quiet, Adora? I know it's not a vision." She hears Catra call out. They've been traveling for the better part of a week now and they are finally nearing the first town. Adora is a bundle of nerves over it.

She turns to look at the thief. "How would you know?"

She comes around, her hands busy whittling down a piece of wood. "It's a different look on your face. Like you've clocked out of your own body." She informs. Her eyes dare Adora to contradict her.

She doesn't know how Catra could even see her expression from clear across the camp they've made. "—She doesn't want to lie. Lying as an oracle is a dangerous business. It makes you nauseous and, if an oracle lies enough, it could lead to death. But more than the consequences, it hurts her heart to think of lying to Catra. "I'd rather not talk about."

"Are you ever going to tell me anything you'd rather not say?" Catra huffs as she sits next to Adora. "Or is being purposefully vague part of the oracle mystique?"

"Yeah. Kind of." She shrugs. "As an oracle, you only have your words. Your knowledge. It can be dire to misspeak."

The brunette raises an eyebrow. "How?"

"Well for one, many people don't like the future. And they will quite literally kill the messenger." Adora has thankfully avoided a worse fate but she'd taken a beating or two before she quickly learned that she needed to be smart about how she spoke of her visions.

"Oh. I suppose that makes sense."A shadow crosses Catra's face. "That must feel very lonely ."She mentions softly . Catra is looking at her with something more than sympathy~~it's~~ the reflection of another outcast soul. Adora knows the look well.

A sigh escapes her lungs. "It is."She agrees. "It's not that I don't want to tell you things,"Adora admits. If anything, it's hard not to share with Catra. Not to try to get as close as she's able. "I just worry. Some things are hard to know."She can't tell Catra how she's been doomed by meeting Adora. How Adora has both longed for and dreaded the day she would meet Catra.

The thief eyes her, looking at Adora like she can see right through her. "Must be harder to know them alone, I'd think."

"That's true."She admits.

"Fine, won't ask you about your visions."She clears her throat. "But will you tell me one thing?"

Adora nods. "Sure."It's the least she could do for the woman who has freed her. The woman she fears that she might love. Adora braces herself for whatever Catra might ask.

Her eyes hold humor in them and she tries to stop the twitch of her lips. "What's your favorite color?"

Adora gapes at her. "You can ask a question of an oracle and you ask that?"

Catra shakes her head. "I'm asking a question of Adora."She clarifies.

Adora feels a lump in her throat. She's not sure anyone has asked her a question like this, not in the thousands of questions she was forced to answer every day since her gift was discovered. "Yellow. It reminds me of the sun. I love the sun."She remembers so many

days as a child running in the fields with her brother, Adam before she was taken from her family.

Catra hums. "I like blue myself. I find rain soothing."She tells Adora. There's a slight smile on her face. "When I was young, I'd look out the window of the orphanage when it rained. No one cared as much then. I could look outside and just watch the heavens fall on our town. I'd do anything to be outside in it."She laughs, a squeaky thing that immediately takes whatever part of her heart Adora had managed to cling onto for herself. "I caught pneumonia once that way. Almost died."She informs Adora gleefully .

"Catra."Adora scolds like that brunette recently made the decision. "You could have gotten hurt."

She shrugs. "No one would have missed me if something happened to me back then."

"I really doubt that."Adora isn't sure what would have happened to her if Catra met some untimely end. She cares less about her imprisonment and more about the thought that they might have never met. It feels like her bones would have ached at the loss, even if she didn't understand why .

"It's neither here nor there,"Catra says dismissively . "For whatever reason, I seem best at staying alive. I've used it to my advantage countless times."

"Well, I'm grateful for it."The statement is a little too honest, a little too much for two strangers backpacking together purely out of kindness or convenience. "If not, I'd still be trapped."She reminds the thief.

To her surprise, Catra blushes. "Anyone would have done that."She says dismissively.

"That's not true, Catra. I've been in hundreds of positions where it would have cost someone nothing to turn a blind eye and let me

escape. Most people want the reward that a ruler will give them if they turn over the oracle."It feels her with the same tired sadness it always does that a majority of people she's met in her life see her as no better than cattle, property to be subjugated until it produces the desired results.

"I think that speaks to the terrible nature of people near power more than it does to anything special I might have done."Catra counters, crossing her arms across her chest.

Adora sighs. She can tell it's a lost cause to try and pester Catra into accepting a compliment. At least, not without giving away too much about how she feels about the brunette. "We will have to agree to disagree I suppose."

The brunette stands up, walking toward the bedroll she'd set up earlier. In the dark of the night and at this distance, it's hard to make out Catra's eyes. "I'll allow that if you can see that we can have a normal conversation without it turning into a cryptic bout about the future."

Adora feels herself burn. "You have to forgive me for being out of practice with normal conversation."She wonders if she's bored Catra this week, or made her frustrated. The idea of the brunette finding her lacking made something inside Adora want to shy away.

"There's nothing to forgive."She says softly. Adora wishes she could still make you her expression in the dim light, but the nightfall has made that near impossible. "You'll just follow my lead tomorrow when we finally reach civilization."

When they get into town the next day, Adora is beside herself with curiosity and nerves. She's never been in a normal town, not since she was a teenager and she accompanied her mother to the market. This was different and it had been years since then anyway. Adora is a different person now.

She tries to keep her face neutral, to not focus on anything for too long, lest it trigger a vision. Catra holds her arm, steering her from the outskirts of town to the very heart of it. They enter a bar that seems to be in a humble part of town—one of the royalty that she typically interacted with would be caught dead there. They make their way inside, walking toward the barkeep who she supposed is in charge not only of the bar but the inn above it.

"Follow my lead." The brunette whispers in her ear . Catra casually wraps her arm around Adora's waist and Adora just about has a heart attack. "We are looking for a room," Catra asks sweetly , her eyes only on the barkeep. "If we could get some privacy , it would be great. My wife and I are on vacation. I'd hate to bother the other patrons." Catra looks over at Adora at the mention of privacy .

The barkeep titters at Catra's doting look but Adora thinks she might pass out from all the blood rushing to her face. "Of course! How refreshing to see a young couple be in love and together." The young woman buys Catra's story without question and they are off to their room.

The moment the door closes, Adora turns on the brunette. "Why did you say that?" She hisses.

Catra shrugs. "Couples get discounts and privacy . It's a good strategy." She smirks and ducks her head. "Does that bother you, princess?"

"No, I'm unbothered." She refuses to admit just how bothered she is and she will absolutely not think of the word wife and Catra in the same sentence ever again. She looks around at the room they are meant to share for however long their stay is. It's a barebone setup, with only a bed and a small bedside table along with a chair in the corner. Still, Adora is free to come and go as she pleases so it's better than all the palace cages she's encountered before. She turns to look at Catra. "What are we doing in this town?"

"I need information to figure out where you would be safe." She explains. "You still want to find somewhere to live on your own right?" Catra verifies with a raised eyebrow.

It's what Adora had insisted she wanted once she had a few days to think about it. She knows she's likely free of all royalty now that the prophecy is complete, but it's best not to tempt fate. Besides, there are other things she's looking to prevent from happening and that's almost always a fool's errand. She needs her best chance.

"Yes. I need to be somewhere I can hide. I can't integrate into a place like this." She can't even begin to imagine the nightmare of masking her visions would be. Besides, as much as she's enjoyed Catra's company, she needs distance from the brunette.

She nods. "Alright. I have a friend who tends to stay around here. We can meet her tomorrow. She'll help us." Catra promises as she shucks off her boots.

Adora turns her eyes away, feeling her mouth run dry. "If you trust her to help, then I trust her too." She knows that Catra wouldn't bring her to someone that would hurt her.

Catra glares. "You're still being too trusting. You should at least ask me questions." She says gruffly.

Adora grins. "Can't you just assume I have seen the future and know that this person is safe?"

"I would except it seems obvious you didn't do that." She huffs. Catra eyes her for a moment. "I'm not revealing your status if I can help it. I think we can find what we need without too many details. But if for whatever reason, Glimmer finds out about who you are, I'm sure I can convince her to keep her mouth shut." She assures, even though Adora asked for no such reassurances.

"Thank you, Catra. For helping me. I'll find a way to repay you." She says instead. Adora isn't sure why Catra has extended this level of

courtesy to her but it warms her nonetheless.

The rogue bites her lip, looking away. "Think nothing of it, princess." She says softly. Adora's unsure where the nickname came from but she enjoys it too much to ask questions. Especially when Catra looks back up with that softness etched on her face. "I'll make sure you get to where you need to be safe."

It's a promise that makes Adora feel all kinds of things she knows she shouldn't.

It's a vision like many of the ones Adora experienced recently, but she can tell that it's not the same. She's submerged in it, she can feel the cold of the wind, smell the firewood, and she can more than see her and Catra laying together in a bed. Catra's fingers are devoted to her, they never stray as they linger up and down Adora's arm.

Adora knows exactly what vision this is and she already hates it.

"I love you, princess," Catra murmurs into her skin, placing soft kisses anywhere she can reach.

"I love you too." The Adora in her arms responds sleepily. She looks boneless and relaxed in a way that simply can't be feigned.

It's a tranquil moment between lovers, like many that Adora has seen with her sight. Yet it's never less jarring when the door is opened and a horde of cloaked people burst in. Like every time, Catra throws herself in front of Adora, sparing her from a lethal blow. Catra falls off the bed hunched over coughing blood.

"Catra, no!" Adora sobs, holding herself over Catra's body.

She sees the other Adora try to push away her love's murderers, desperate to hold her until the end. They don't grant small mercies, pulling her away as Catra stares wide-eyed, hand twitching toward

the door, toward Adora. Only she can watch as Catra slowly breathes out. Only she knows that Catra's last word is Adora's name on her lips, an untimely end she's watched over and over.

Adora wakes up panting shooting right out of bed. She's already crying but she reminds herself that it's a vision that hasn't happened to Catra. It doesn't have to if she just keeps herself in line.

She feels warm sure hands on her arm and then two beautiful eyes looking at her with concern. "Bad dream?" Catra asks gently, her eyes roving Adora's face.

Adora still hasn't caught her breath. "Bad vision." She admits. "Go to sleep." Adora pleads. She feels so weak with relief at this moment, seeing Catra alive~~sh~~e worried what she might do.

Catra shakes her head, settling herself more firmly to Adora's side. "Adora, you're shaking." She runs a hand into Adora's hair, a soothing motion she hasn't felt since before she was an oracle. She almost wants to weep from the comfort it brings. "What did you see that has you like this?" Her voice is drenched in worry.

"I ~~c~~ant" ~~S~~he takes a shuddering breath as she feels a roll of nausea.

Catra seems to sense something because she doesn't push, instead just holds her. "Whatever it is...it'll sort itself, Adora." She murmurs softly, continuing to comfort her.

She shakes her head but Catra seems to think she's just shaking from crying. Adora can't even enjoy being held by Catra right now, not fully, because she's not meant to have this. Not if she wants to keep Catra alive. Her tears slowly ebb and Catra continues to hold her. She starts running her hand over Adora's arm and it strikes her that she's holding Adora the same way she did in the vision, tender and careful.

It makes Adora sob harder. She can't deny it any longer, at least to herself. She loves Catra. But she can't let Catra fall in love with her, not if she wants any chance of saving her. Yet, Adora is weak at the moment. She lets Catra comfort her and lets herself fall asleep in the brunette's arms, promising herself to fight fate tomorrow.

The next morning is mostly quiet. Catra can tell that Adora doesn't want to talk about whatever scared her last night and it takes everything in her not to corner the blonde and ask anyway. It's none of her business, but it feels like it should be. She's the one who had to lull the blonde back to sleep, her heart clenching painfully in her chest as Adora sobbed and clung to her like a lifeline.

It's none of Catra's business. They're barely friends and Catra is just helping her get to where she needs to be out of some misplaced affection that will surely rot her from the inside out. She shakes her head, leading Adora through the streets of Eleberon, looking for a sign of Glimmer. She finally catches a glimpse of her friend, casually walking toward the back of a building.

Cara turns to the oracle. "We are meeting a friend." She explains this to Adora again the next morning. "Make sure to keep everything quiet about who you are." She narrows her eyes as she says the warning. She knows Adora is intelligent and resourceful, but she doesn't need her tipping Glimmer off.

Adora rolls her eyes. "That's a given. I do what I can to stay covert, you know?"

Catra holds back a scoff. Barely anything about Adora is covert. Not the way she stares when she has a vision, not her hair like gold or eyes like sapphires. She's striking in every sense. "Stay here. I'm going to talk to her for a minute and then I'll introduce you." She orders.

Catra keeps looking back making sure that Adora is doing her level best to be discrete. She receives a thunderous glare from the blonde

that makes her feel a little sheepish. She finally turns and makes her way down an alley, knowing that Glimmer will follow. Sure enough, the moment she's isolated enough, her friend comes into view.

"Glimmer." She gives her friend an easy smile. Catra doesn't trust many people, but Glimmer makes the shortlist. "I need a favor." She leans against the alleyway, watching as Glimmer sizes her up.

"Cut the shit, Catra." She huffs. "I know you came into town with a gorgeous blonde hanging off your arm. The same blonde you left sitting twenty yards away. So, paint me a picture real quick of what's happening or I'm going to have Bow put an arrow through her shoulder."

Catra rolls her eyes. "So aggressive, Glimmer." She crosses her arms. "Not everyone is trying to turn you in, you know?"

"Paint a picture." She bears her teeth and Catra knows she has to come clean. There's no reasoning with Glimmer when she suspects her mother might be involved.

"I need help finding a place to hide the blonde. Somewhere no one can find. Especially royalty." Catra explains quickly.

Glimmer shakes her head, a smirk forming. "Come on, Catra! You were going to bring the oracle and not share a slice of the action?" She rolls her eyes. "And you thought I wouldn't recognize her?"

Shit. Catra forgot that given her background, Glimmer would know a lot more about the oracle than the average person. The same knowledge that made her useful made it easy for her to see Adora for what she is.

"No. I'm keeping her safe Glimmer." Catra walks closer, peering over the shorter woman. "You can't hurt her."

She looks genuinely surprised at that. "Oh. Why?" Glimmer asks with a furrowed brow.

"Because she's a person!" Catra bursts out. "I'm not going to just hand her over to be imprisoned for the rest of her life! There are no jewels worth losing Adora. The thought that she's suffered as long as she has makes Catra angry at the injustice of it. She's kind and good, she doesn't deserve this.

Glimmer's face softens at that "Okay, okay. You have a point." She gives Catra a sheepish grin. "It feels weird to think of her as an actual person." She admits.

"Adora is a good person. She doesn't deserve this." She tells Glimmer seriously.

It makes the shorter woman take a step back, her hand coming up to Catra's shoulder. "You really...care, don't you? About her."

Catra isn't expecting the observation so she stumbles. "Yeah. I'd say we're friends." It hasn't been long, but there's something about Adora that feels like a kindred spirit. Like someone she understands.

"Huh. Okay." She says slowly before nodding to herself. "A friend of yours is a friend of mine. As long as they aren't a friend of the crown." Glimmer adds with a glare.

"She's not a friend of *any* crown, Glimmer." How could she be, with the life she's lived?

She shoots Catra a dubious look, her arms crossing over her chest. "You sure? She sure seems cozy with them."

"They want to keep her like a bird in a cage," Catra explains, pulling her hood back slightly so Glimmer can see her fully. "She's as much of a victim as you are. Maybe more."

That makes her shoulders drop, looking out in the direction they came from. "Alright. Bow will be watching my back in case anything happens."

Catra smirks at that. "Oh, so you two have sorted yourselves?" She laughs when the other woman goes instantly pink, drawing up her own hood to hide her blush. "I know that you know there's no danger, otherwise you wouldn't have told me Bow was watching." With that, Catra walks forward, leaving a flummoxed Glimmer to follow after her.

As they reach Adora, Catra watches a flash of recognition cross the oracle's face. "Glimmer." She sounds pleased to see her as if they're friends. Adora looks distant for a few moments before smiling. "Queen Angella was very kind to me once. She misses you."

Glimmer gapes at the blonde. "How did you—"

"Oracle." Catra reminds her before whipping around to glare at Adora. "What happened to not telling people things?" She hisses. Their cover was already blown but it's the principle of the matter.

She shrugs with a lopsided smile. It makes Catra's heart beat faster. "Oh, I just remembered her portrait in the castle." She looks at Glimmer again. "When I was captured by your mother, she asked a lot about you." She informs her kindly. "Have you met any ...men out in the forest?" Her eyes are bright and excited as she asks the question.

Glimmer looks like she might have an aneurysm. "I don't know how it's any of your business." She grumbles. "Well, he has his arrows trained on you so I guess it is kind of your business."

Instead of being appalled by the news, Adora gets an almost dreamy look in her eyes. "Oh that's splendid, I had seen it but I always wondered...I'm happy you found Bow."

"Okay!" Catra interrupts before Glimmer could give Bow the sign to maim Adora. "Glimmer, we need somewhere safe for Adora to go into hiding. You're the queen of disappearing." The former princess has been hiding from everyone who has been searching for her for the better part of a decade now.

Glimmer gives Catra a tired look before looking at Adora. "She's going to be harder to hide than me. I was only of concern to one kingdom, she will be of concern to many."She puts her hand under her chin as she thinks. "I don't think it's enough for her to hide the way that Bow and I do."She confesses.

Catra can feel her heart sink at the news. She'd really hoped Glimmer would have an idea of what they could do to keep Adora safe. "There's really nothing you can think of?"She asks, a tinge of desperation creeping into her voice.

"Not that I can do. But I have an idea."She looks between Catra and Adora. "Okay , there's this witch. She's supposed to know all kinds of things. My thinking is, if anyone knows what Adora should do, it'll be her."She advises.

"Where is she?"Catra demands. This is exactly the kind of lead they are looking for.

Glimmer winces. "You have to go to the Whispering Woods."

She groans, covering her face. "That's so far ,"Catra complains. They have to double back the full way they came and then travel another week on top of that.

"Well, it's not like she's going to set up in the Bright Moon marketplace."Glimmer snarks with a roll of her eyes.

"Fair point."She begrudgingly admits. She sighs, looking up at the blonde. "I guess we have a lot of traveling to do still."

Adora nods. "I'm sorry if this interferes with your plans."She bites her lip, looking down at the ground. "I can try to find my own way ." She offers.

The thought makes Catra's heart clench. "No, it's okay . I'm happy to take you there."She assures the blonde. Adora would probably get captured before she made it out of town. Catra isn't going to let that

happen. She realizes she's staring too intently when Glimmer clears her throat. The shorter woman has a smirk on her face that makes Catra feel called out. "Shut up, Glimmer ."She mumbles. "Do you have any instructions more specific than the entirety of the Whispering Woods?"

The trek to the witch's house is a long one that took them mostly into the forest again. The good thing is that it keeps them out of sight and that Catra is adept at hiding them. It's an easy thing to get used to, spending all day with the thief walking side by side, telling each other stories and jokes, working together to set up camp, and then dismantling it in the morning. Every day they grow closer to parting and although logically Adora knows it's for the best, she's still struggling with the thought of saying goodbye to Catra.

They've been walking for an hour in almost complete silence, both lost in thought. Adora appreciates this, how often she and Catra can fall into silence and then fall back into the conversation as if it never happened. It never feels award or forced. She's really going to miss it. Adora almost trips when she processes the abrupt words Catra throws her way.

"What if you stayed?"Catra's voice is casual like this isn't a big deal. Maybe to Catra, it doesn't seem it.

For a second, she thinks maybe Catra is reading her mind. She's not sure why else she'd bring this up. "With you?"Adora asks tentatively .

"Y eah."Catra grins. "W e can make a decent thief of you yet."She teases softly, bumping her shoulder into Adora's.

It sounds like a dream, to roam around with Catra forever, making a home wherever they have each other. But it's not possible. At least, not without putting Catra in danger.

"I don't think it's a good idea."She says softly . Beyond putting Catra in danger, Adora has nothing to offer her. She's useless from her soft

life as a captive. She only has her visions to offer, and if even that comes at a great personal cost.

"Oh." Catra looks taken aback, her eyes widening as she takes Adora in. "I'm sorry, I thought I-I thought we were having a good time." She says shyly.

Adora's heart pangs. "We are. But I need to-I need to find my own way, I think." The words feel heavy and false on her tongue as she lets them drop from her lips. Her body is torn with emotions: elation that Catra wants her to stay, fear of what it means that the brunette wants that, and heartbreak at having to reject her. She wants to assure her, to tell Catra that nothing would make her happier, but that would lead to discussions Adora can't afford to have with the brunette.

Catra straightens up, keeping her eyes steady ahead of them. "Very well. It was just a suggestion. Think nothing of it." She recommends stiffly.

She speeds up and Adora stares after her, not sure how to fix things. Not sure if she'll only make it worse.

She can't stop thinking about the sting of rejection. Adora had looked uncomfortable that Catra had the gall to ask her to stay the thought had probably never crossed the oracle's mind. Why would it? It was probably ridiculous for Catra to suggest.

Things are back to normal between them since Catra's total lapse in judgment. That night, Adora had given her a soft smile and told her about the stars and some of the stories that older oracles she'd happened to meet passed down to her. It was a clear apology for whatever harm had come between them. Now they are walking through the forest carefully, toward a plan that, if all goes well, means that Catra has no need or reason to see the blonde ever again.

She swallows roughly at the thought. They only have a week of travel left. She reaches out and grabs Adora's arm quickly, hearing something that she shouldn't this deep in the forest marching. "Adora, come here." She hisses, shoving the oracle into the underbrush before she can say a word.

She pulls Adora flush to her and lays her body over the blonde in hopes of camouflaging her. Catra can hear the heavy footfall of the soldiers as they search the area, yelling Adora's name. Catra rolls her eyes. As if being loud bullies is going to make Adora come to them. It's a good twenty minutes before Catra can breathe again and chances a look up into the forest. It seems they are truly alone.

It takes her a minute before she registers just how close she and Adora are. The blonde is looking at her with wide eyes, her breath coming in short pants due to the surprise. Catra's hand found its way into her hair, the other around her waist. It feels intimate, holding Adora like this while she looks up at Catra with stormy blue eyes. For a moment, she can't find it within her to speak. She can almost imagine leaning down and capturing the blonde's lips with her own. She rolls off of her, waiting for her hearr to calm down before she looks back at the blonde.

"They are searching for you." Catra points out. It isn't the first call they have with soldiers but it is the closest they've come to discovery. It rattles Catra to think that if she'd been paying even a little less attention Adora would be captured again now.

"That's not new." Adora dismisses. "They'll never stop looking."

"But what would you have done if you were alone?" She whispers, taking a step closer to the blonde. Adora isn't capable of fending for herself yet. At least not with the way she's being hunted. It makes Catra angry. It snaps something inside of her, the will to be agreeable and to let the blonde go without a fight. "You're being stubborn risking yourself for what? Am I so intolerable to you?" Catra can't help but ask.

She'd offered Adora a decent alternative. Instead of risking her life trusting some witch they didn't even know, Catra could protect her. She knows she's capable of it—she's been doing it since the moment she met Adora. It must be Catra's company that Adora seeks to reject. No other option makes sense.

Her eyes widen and she grabs Catra's hands to provide comfort. Her eyes look watery like she might start crying. "No, Catra. You don't understand!"

Catra understands plenty. "What am I, not part of this amorphous future you can see? I make my own way, Adora and you can too." She's begging now. This encounter has left Catra with a huge pit in her stomach, thinking about Adora alone and defenseless somewhere out there. And if she's really honest with herself, even just the thought of Adora apart from her makes her feel this way.

She shakes her head, her blonde hair falling over her shoulder. "It's not"—

"Who cares if you don't see me in your future?" She spits out.

She's not important enough for that—Catra knows her lot in life. But it hurts to have Adora dismiss her this way as if they haven't built anything. But maybe it's true. Maybe the only thing that's built is the thoughts in her head and the feelings in her chest. Maybe Adora simply sees her as someone who helped her, a rare person who showed her kindness. Maybe that's why it's so easy for her to reject her.

Adora sighs deeply, blue eyes sad as she stares at her. "Catra. When I think of my future, all I can see is you." She whispers.

It grinds Catra's mind to a halt, making the blood thrum in her veins, hot and strong. "What do you mean?" She demands. It makes no sense with everything else that's happened between them.

"It's Catra I've had visions of you since I was fifteen." She gives Catra a tremulous smile. "My very first vision was of you." She confesses.

She blinks slowly eyeing Adora. Catra has no idea what it means. "So when you saw me the first time... you recognized me?" It seems impossible, to think that she's crossed Adora's visions in that way and she didn't even know it.

"Yes. Of course, I did." She lets out a disbelieving laugh, shaking her face. "I didn't know your name, but I knew your face, Catra."

A horrible thought strikes her. "Do I do something to you in the future? That you don't want to stay?" Catra can't imagine ever doing anything to hurt Adora but she's not the one who can see what's to come.

Adora's face crumbles as tears well in her eyes. "No. *I* hurt *you*." She takes a slow breath, trying to steady herself. "You know the visions I've had at night?" She prompts.

Catra nods wordlessly. She'd do anything to get rid of the haunted look in Adora's eyes when she woke from one of those awful things. She can't sleep after, watching Adora sleep. Catra knows she can't stop the visions but she still feels like she's guarding against them when she holds Adora in her sleep.

"It's usually the same vision. You die in my arms until they drag me away." The haunted look is back with a vengeance and Catra just wants to wrap her arms around Adora but she isn't sure if that'll make it worse. "It's my fault. Someone is looking for me and they kill you for standing in their way."

Catra thinks she should probably feel more hearing about a way she could die, but honestly, it could be worse. "It's not your fault if someone tries to hurt me." She reasons.

"It is! You know what I am—how dangerous it is to be associated with me." She reminds Catra fiercely.

"I do know. And yet, I want you to stay with me anyway." Catra reaches her hand out and dares to touch Adora's tear-stricken cheek. "If I choose to stand between you and those that wish to harm you, then that's my right." She repeats the words that Adora told her when she first decided to trust Catra.

She remembers how disbelieving she was that Adora would place her faith in her. Now she knows Adora is right to do so because there's no way she'd ever do anything to try and hurt her. Regardless of whether they're friends or something more, Catra knows she'd lay down her life for Adora without a doubt. She'd rather not have to, but if it came down to it, it would be an easy choice.

"You shouldn't have to." She juts out her chin in that stubborn way when she thinks she's right. It makes Catra want to drop a kiss there.

"That's not the point. What do you *want*, Adora?" She asks, gently tipping her face down so Catra can more fully see her expression.

She looks torn, her eyes still watering. "What I want doesn't matter."

"It matters to me." Catra bites her lip to keep from saying more—she doesn't need to make a fool of herself. Or more of a fool, she supposes. Her feelings are probably plain as day on her face.

"I want you to be well and happy and *alive*." Adora finally bites out, her head bending down to rest on Catra's shoulder. "That's why I can't stay. No matter how badly I might want to."

The tremble in her voice tugs at Catra's heart. She wraps her arms around Adora. "If you want to stay with me, you'd make me the happiest woman alive, you know." She whispers into the blonde's ear,

Adora scoffs, her head bumping Catra's shoulder with the force of the sound. "You're just saying that."

Catra tightens her arms around Adora and she feels the blonde cling back. She runs a hand down her back as she tries to gather her courage. She's been at the edge of death before but this feels ten times more terrifying.

"Adora, I love you." She feels the blonde tense in her arm so she loses her grip. Adora doesn't take a step back so she continues. "I know it's too much, too soon but"—

Adora's hand comes up and presses on her lips. She raises herself a little so they are eye to eye again, her smile surprisingly tender. "I love you too, Catra." She admits freely , eyes clear as lakes. "That's why I want you safe."

Her heart beats hard in her chest. Adora—she feels the same. "I'd rather be in danger with you, than anywhere else in the world." Catra knows what it was like to wander lost, to not have much meaning before the next heist, the next exchange, never trusting anyone with her secrets. She's done with that.

"If the roles were reversed, what would you do?" Adora challenges. "Wouldn't you want to keep me safe?"

She stares at the blonde, truly considering her. "I'd let you make your own choice," Catra says finally . "Because I know that the future is uncertain. And the present is fleeting."

Adora looks at her for a moment. "It feels selfish, to get to love you." She confesses.

It makes Catra's whole being throb, the thought of having Adora's love. "Then be selfish for once." She urges. Catra leans forward, pressing their foreheads together. "Isn't it about time you get to live your life the way you want?" She whispers, hoping beyond hope to be the thing that Adora wants.

The blonde pulls her even closer still, sealing their lips together and sealing their fate.

Adora is weak is what she is. She shouldn't be entertaining this, she should keep herself from Catra but it feels impossible. She's back in bed with Catra only now they are a couple and they share it in every sense of the word. Catra's hands are soothing as they slowly trail up her spine, her kisses never ceasing.

"Your skin is soft." Catra marvels as she continues to pepper it with kisses. "I could never tire of this." She almost mumbles it to herself. Catra is every bit as warm and in love as Adora saw her in her visions and it is as thrilling as it is heart-wrenching. The thought that she could be taken from Adora makes her tremble.

Instead of focusing on that, she tugs on Catra's arm, pulling her so that she's next to Adora instead of draped over her back. She turns so that she's facing Catra. Her head is propped on her hand as she smiles softly at Adora. She raises an eyebrow. "Are you tired?" She teases, before leaning forward and kissing her languidly.

Adora returns the kiss the equal fervor, red-cheeked by the time it ends. She'd shyly admitted to Catra that no one had dared touch her during her captivity either for fear that it would somehow make her gift defective or that the royals would punish anyone who dared touch their possession. Catra had been beyond patient, letting Adora do what felt right which, honestly, had been most of what they did together. Adora didn't know someone could feel like this, even with her visions warning her of this outcome.

"I'm not too tired." She replies before kissing the brunette. She makes sure to press against her, enjoying Catra's nakedness against her frame. It's incredible how soft she can be when she's so strong too. Adora must have been born under a blessed star to get to have her like this. "Can I touch you?"

She leans back, letting Adora take the lead. "Of course." She agrees. For a second her smile dims. "Do you still want to try and find the witch tomorrow?"

They'd taken a detour, stopping their journey for a week and staying in a town on the edge of the Whispering Woods. Adora had insisted they find the woman anyway, in hopes that she could still provide insights on hiding. She nods at Catra. "Yes. I think it's worth speaking with her if Glimmer thinks she might know something useful." Adora has her own questions she needs to answer anyway.

Catra nods seriously. "Alright, we will find her tomorrow then." She promises. Her eyes drag down over Adora's skin and she feels warm again. Catra smirks. "Now, you said something about touching?" She traces a hand down the slope between Adora's breasts, her fingers lingering there.

She moves so Catra is flush on the mattress, caged by Adora's arms. She loves the excited look on Catra's face she just can't hide, the way her eyes widen and pupils dilate as she takes Adora in. "Count on it." She whispers into her hair.

One day, Adora will be strong enough to leave Catra for her own good. Today simply isn't that day.

It takes most of the morning to figure out Glimmer's vague instructions, but they are finally where they need to be. Catra looks like she's about to march into the small cottage but Adora grabs her hand.

"Catra, I need to do this on my own." Now that she's in front of it, Adora is almost certain she's seen this cottage before in a vision. She can't place it but she can sense the magic and importance of the place.

Her lover looks vexed, her gaze narrowed on Adora. "You don't have to do everything on your own"—

Adora presses a soft kiss to her lips to silence Catra. "I know ."She agrees, "But I have a feeling. T rusting my intuition is kind of my whole thing."

She looks at Adora with a defeated look on her face. "I dont like it." She states plainly.

"T rust me?"She asks quietly .

Catra softens at that. "I'll be right outside. Y ell if you need me to rescue you."She says seriously .

Adora rolls her eyes. "I think once in a lifetime was enough, love."

Her eyes get all glassy, a thrilling development Adora discovered when she recently tried the nickname out on Catra. "Y oure not playing fair."She accuses with a pouting lip. Adora grins placing another soft kiss on her forehead. Catra sighs. "Go before I change my mind and follow you in there."

Adora nods and makes her way up to the cottage. Its dilapidated, the sides crusted in the mud like no one has cleaned it in ages. For a moment, Adora considers that maybe Glimmer is mistaken, that she gave them the wrong directions. Still, something tells her shes where shes meant to be. She walks up to the door and knocks firmly.

"The door is open, dearie! Y ou know this!"She hears yelled out from inside. It sounds like an old woman.

She hesitates for a moment. Clearly, she thinks its someone else. But what else can she do, sit outside hoping for her to notice? Adora slowly opens the door. What she finds isnt really what she expects. The witch seems to be baking something, kneading dough on the counter.

She looks at Adora and doesnt seem too concerned that there is a stranger in her home. "Did you bring the blueberries?"She asks

urgently, eyes barely moving off the dough.

She's not sure what *that* is supposed to mean, so she lets it lie. "Um, hello. My name is Adora, I'm"—

The woman flaps her arms. "Yes, the last oracle of Eternia. I know, dearie." She sounds like she has no patients for Adora's tardiness or her introduction.

She furrows her brow. "How do you know?" Adora knows she has a recognizable face, but the woman hasn't even looked up at her really.

"Well, Madame Razz knows a thing or two about seeing the future." She looks up and there's a knowing look there as she waits for Adora to catch on.

She gapes at the woman. "You're—you're an oracle too?" It's been so long since she's run into someone like her.

The old woman rolls her eyes. "Yes, dearie. Keep up!" She urges with a smile. "Now, did you bring blueberries?"

Adora furrows her brow. "No, I didn't." She admits, not sure if she's already failed some test.

Madame Razz shrugs. "No matter. We will find a pie filling another way." She tosses Ador a side-long glance. "Maybe the handsome woman who's standing in front of my cottage could bring something from the forest." She suggests.

Adora feels herself blush, somehow feeling like she's been caught doing something she isn't supposed to. "Catra isn't one for errands." Adora won't have her traipsing about the Whispering Woods to please some woman they just meant, as innocuous as she looks.

"You're still thinking of leaving her, dearie." Adora is about to ask her how she even knows when Madame Razz gives her an exasperated

look. "I know why you seek me. You want answers about the fate of your love. Not whatever story you fed her to get her to accompany you here."

Adora isn't usually the person with less information in a conversation. She's finding it tiresome. "I didn't lie. You know as well as I do that I can't lie without physical consequences."

"Half-truths are just as painful." She says sagely as she covers the dough to rest. "You have doubts about your future. You've never tried to change it, always following your gift. You want to defy it now."

She feels a spark of righteous anger fill her. "Can you blame me?" She demands. "Catra doesn't deserve to die because some prophecy or vision wills it. She's special and sweet, she~~she~~ deserves better than this." She deserves better than what Adora can provide her.

Madame Razz shakes her head, moving toward the living room and beckoning Adora to follow. "Our gift isn't perfect, Adora."

"But I've seen enough to know." She protests. Adora has seen it over and over again. Beat per beat she can see it in her mind's eye at any moment.

"You haven't." Razz shakes her head, almost giving her a pitying look. "Love isn't a weakness. It's strength. That's what you have to remember."

The old woman sits and "But I~~how~~ can I live with it? Knowing she'll be hurt?"

"It's her choice. Make it worth her while." Madam Razz advises.

"I can't live with myself if she's hurt because of me," Adora admits.

Madame Razz sighs. "I didn't want it to come to this." As if she'd been holding it since they sat down, Madame Razz shows her a

bottle in the palm of her hand. "This vial contains a very dangerous liquid. If you were to drink this with your Catra, you would unbind the string between you."

"What does that mean?" Adora can't help but ask.

"It would make it so that your fates wouldn't be tied. Right now, for many reasons, the universe has seen it fit for you two to be connected." She pulls on an imaginary string. "The string might tangle or tug but it will never break on its own. To severe the connection means to create a blanket slate."

"Would we...would we still be in love?" Adora asks.

"Yes, dearie. It wouldn't change how you feel, it would only sever the string. This means that you might not be free forever of captivity, as you prophesized."

Something clicks in Adora's mind. "Is the price of my guaranteed freedom Catra's death?"

Madame Razz nods solemnly. "That's right, child. The universe gives but it takes as well. For the peace of mind and eternal freedom, you would lose your love."

"So if we took this, she'd live?" She asks desperately. Adora would trade capture for Catra's life any day.

"No! It's like you aren't an oracle!" Madame Razz cries. "Life is uncertain, Adora. There's no telling if she would knock her head on a rock and die or if you'd avoid capture anyway. It would sever the prophecy because it's rooted in the connection between you two." She sighs. "It also means that you would not always be able to find each other. You'd be like every other pair of lovers, doomed to fail or succeed on your own merit. No help from the gods."

"Why do you know all this?" Adora can't help but ask. It feels to go to be true, someone with all the answers she's been seeking, not only

about Catra but about the prophecy that has ruled her life.

"When you're as old as I am, you've seen things, dearie. I've seen so many lives I can't even tell you when I am."She sighs, her wrinkled hands trembling.

Adora feels some remorse for disturbing the old woman. "I'm sorry ."

She smiles, her eyes crinkling. "Nonsense. Remember , you always have a choice. Now, unless you want something else, I think that you have much to discuss with the thief loitering outside my home."

Adora is entirely too quiet for days after seeing the witch. She gets vision after vision, spacing out even worse than usual. It has Catra on pins and needles. The only thing that keeps Catra from full-blown panicking is that Adora doesn't withdraw from her . If anything she seems even more content to kiss and touch her when she's not in the fog of her visions.

"Adora."She calls, finally unable to keep waiting for Adora to come forward. So much for patience. "What happened with the witch?"

Her blue eyes get wide as she looks at Catra, a trace of nervousness overcoming her visage. "She gave me a lot to think about. Something I think we have to decide together."She adds hesitantly . "Give me a minute."Adora steps out and leaves the room before coming back with something clutched in her hand. She carefully puts it on the table in front of them. "The witch, Madame Razz, gave me this."

Catra eyes the bottle dubiously. "W ell, you don't drink something a witch gives you. That's like, basic survival."She hasn't survived this long being stupid and drinking something just because a witch asked her to. She'll be damned if she lets Adora do it either .

She shakes her head slowly. "Madame Razz isn't actually a witch. She's an oracle like me."Adora explains. "I told her about my

problem and she thinks this might be the only solution."

Catra furrows her brow. "T o hide? What does it do?" She has no idea how a bottle would help Adora hide from the people who want to hurt her.

The blonde looks chagrinned as she reaches out her hand and takes Catra's. "No. I told her about my vision. About how I don't want you to die."

Catra sends her a tired look. "Adora, we've discussed this. If that's what's going to happen then that's okay ."

"But it doesn't have to." She explains. "Not if we both drink this."

"What does it do?" Catra asks again.

Adora sighs. "Have you ever felt like what we have together is special?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "I love you, Adora. Of course, what we have is special."

The blonde smiles lightly at her, making Catra's heart flutter . "I know . But I mean like—have you ever felt, even before we fell in love a connection between us?" She nods slowly . Catra has always felt like she gets Adora, even without words. "That's because we're connected by the universe." She rushes to explain.

"Huh?" She can't help the way she scrunches her face. Thankfully , Adora doesn't take of fense, instead laughing. "I mean it sounds romantic but a little too amorphous for my taste."

"When I told you that I saw you when I was younger in my visions, it was fate ordained," Adora explains slowly . "The visions came with a prophecy. That once someone freed me, I'd never go into captivity again."

Catra smiles squeezing her hand. "So we don't have to worry? You'll be safe?" It feels like bricks of worry falling off of her shoulders and clunking onto the ground. "That's amazing."

Adora shakes her head. "The prophecy comes with a cost." She takes a deep breath. "The cost is you, Catra. Your life. It's my eternal freedom for your life. That's why I keep having the recurring vision."

"Oh." Catra furrows her brow. "Well, if that's what it costs." She shrugs. "You'll be safe." Catra has lived for too long anyway. She's beaten every odd and she won't go down without a fight, but she'd never jeopardize Adora.

"No," Adora says firmly. "We can undo it. This vial holds the key to undoing the prophecy." She points down at it. "We can keep you from certain death, Catra."

"But you'll be captured?"

"Not necessarily." She points out. "I just won't have the guarantee. It's not like we were going to stop trying to stay hidden because of the prophecy anyway. It will be like the situation we thought we were in."

Catra can't help but toss the blonde an irritated glare. "You mean, things will be how I thought they were because you neglected to tell me about how there's apparently a prophecy about us." She says forcefully.

A guilty look flickers across Adora's face. "I'm sorry. I honestly forgot. It's been such a big part of my life, I thought everyone knew it."

Catra waves her hand. "It's fine." She'll give Adora the third degree on whatever else oracle bullshit she thinks is common knowledge that Catra should know some other time.

"There's something else," Adora adds. "The way the potion works. What it does is it severs our connection. The one the universe gave

us. The string that ties us together."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Okay ."

Adora eyes her. "It's a serious thing, Catra. I need you to understand everything this thing does."

Catra leans forward so that she's close to Adora. "Listen. I believe you when you say we have a universal connection, or whatever." Adora rolls her eyes but Catra presses forward. "I even believe you that this woman gave you a potion that could sever it."She moves her hand to cup Adora's cheek. "But I don't believe, for one second, that it would change how I feel about you."She says seriously . "So I don't care about the disruption of whatever yarn or string or connection. I'm holding on to you and I'm going to love you, with or without it."

She's surprised by the fervor with which Adora yanks her close, delivering a bruising kiss. She can hardly breathe but it doesn't matter when it feels like Adora is filling her lungs. When she pulls back her eyes are dark and hooded. "Y ou can't just say things like that, Catra."She breathes out.

She gives Adora a toothy grin. "If that's how you're going to treat me, I'll say them more often."She teases. Catra presses her forehead to Adora's. "In all seriousness, I don't know how I feel about trading your safety for mine."She mutters gruf fly. She'd pick Adora any time, any place. To do anything but that goes against her whole being.

"Catra."There's an edge in Adora's voice. She doesn't move from where they are, pressed together. "Certain death versus the possibility of imprisonment are not the same thing."There's a whine in her voice.

"But even if I die you'd be safe."Catra can't help but point out.

"What's the point of being safe if you're dead"?She demands, tears in her voice. "Think of this: you aren't exchanging my safety for

yours. If we drink this, we will be giving each other more time together. Im more than confident in your ability to protect me if it comes to that. You trying to tell me you cant?"There's a challenge in her voice that Catra recognizes well.

Catra sighs. "Y ou really want to do this?"She knows that these visions have been destroying Adora from the inside. That she hasnt been able to sleep some nights, even with Catra there murmuring in her ear that she's fine and alive. It's chilling when Adora opens her eyes and stares at Catra like she's seeing a ghost.

Adora nods rapidly. "More than anything. I want us to make a future together that's ours. I dont need anyone else to have a say in it." She swears.

Catra nods. "Alright. Let's do it then."

The blonde blinks slowly at her. "That's it?Just like that?"

Catra lets out a chuckle. "Did you want me to make it harder for you?"She wonders.

She rolls her eyes. "No."She then uncorks the vial, holding it up. "Y oure sure?"Her blue eyes peer into Catra'split ones.

"Y es, Adora. I trust you."She repeats the words Adora has told her since the day they met.

The blonde smiles and takes a sip from the vial, making a face before handing it over. Catra grabs it and downs the rest. The liqid is so thick and sludgy, it leaves a thin film all the way down her throat, making her gag. Then suddenly, it's gone, like she'd never drank anything in the first place.

Adora eyes her cautiously. "Do you...still love me?"One of her hands comes up to rest in Catra's hair .

It's such a stupid question. Even still, Catra takes a moment to look at Adora. If she thinks about it closely, there is a certain tug she doesn't feel anymore, but it's swallowed by the depth of feeling she has for the blonde. It makes no difference in how she loves Adora. Catra looks up out of the corner of her eye. "Hmm, you know, I'm really having to search to figure it out." She says seriously. "Maybe you should kiss me so I can make sure." Catra smiles.

Adora smacks her shoulder. "That's not funny!" Still, she obliges Catra, kissing her for all she's worth.

"Did you really believe, for even one moment, that I wouldn't still feel the same?" Catra asks as she presses more kisses on Adora's face and then down her neck.

"You never know." She defends.

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Well then, Adora. Do you still love me?" She feels a little nervous as the blonde eyes her, even though it's silly.

"I can feel the difference," Adora says seriously. "But not in the love I hold for you, Catra." She lets out a soft laugh. "You know, I've experienced and witnessed all manner of love in my visions, but none of them prepared me for you."

Catra kisses her again. "I think...we should go to our bedroom and we can make sure nothing has changed. You know, to be thorough." She proposes as she holds Adora close. It isn't even about lust at that moment. Catra wants to be intimate with Adora, wants to watch all walls fall away as they take care of each other.

Adora nods. "I want that." She affirms before pulling Catra into a deep kiss.

When Catra looks into Adora's eyes, she sees a future that's bright and open. She doesn't need a vision to tell her that she and Adora are meant to last.

End Notes

I worked entirely too long on the Glimbow backstory in my head, only for it to barely make it into the fic lol. I really enjoyed writing this one. Thanks to TaliSands both for helping name and being the inspiration for this fic.

Kudos and comments are fish food (I am a fish today). You can find me on Twitter and Tumblr.

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